

Ear Wax Primary Care Protocol

Version 1.0: Feb 2017

Next review due: Post Covid

Key

- "Must do" actions for GP's / (Triaged by RMS)
- Recommendations for Primary Care
- Red flag / urgent referral
- Routine referral
- Public health intervention
- Audio-visual aids for patients and GP
- Click icon for clinical evidence

Patient presents with earwax, excluding any of the following:

- Abnormal appearance of the outer ear or eardrum including middle ear fluid
- Aural discharge or Otitis lasting >7 days
- sudden onset deterioration in hearing (not Related to wax)
- Unilateral pulsatile or distressing tinnitus
- Complete or partial obstruction of the external auditory canal e.g. foreign body

No

Refer to Community ENT (wax removal/ Microsuction) Service

Yes

Prescribe eardrops to soften wax and aid removal.

- 1) Either olive oil, or almond oil drops can be used first for 10 Days (bottle from Chemist/ Pharmacy). Warm the bottle between palm of hands. Re-check the areas for any abnormal or red flag findings.
- 2) If simple wax remain, advise patient to use Sodium Bicarbonate 5% for further 7-10 Days.

Ear Irrigation may not be suitable for the following patients:

- There is a foreign body, including Vegetable matter, In the ear canal that could swell during irrigation
- Has previously undergone ear surgery (other than grommets insertion that have been extruded for at least 18 months)
- Has a recent history of Otitis and / or middle ear infection (in past 6 Weeks)
- Acute Otitis Externa
- Has a current perforation or history of ear Discharge in The past 12 months
- Has had previous complications following ear irrigation including perforation of the ear drum, severe pain, deafness, or vertigo
- Is housebound and the district nurse is unable to visit

Ear Irrigation contraindicated In primary Care setting

Patient still complains of earwax

Offer ear irrigation (if available) within Primary Care setting i.e. practice nurse or other locally based service.

GP Referral to ENT Community Clinic for earwax removal

A referral for ear wax removal is only commissioned by Barnet CCG for patients meeting the criteria set out, and with the appropriate form filled in with relevant clinical details